

racism and racial injustice, inflation, and climate-related disasters and it's no surprise that stress shopping is the number one impetus for impulse shopping. The American Psychological Association found¹ that 36 percent of American adults said they don't even know where to begin when it comes to managing their stress.

Why does stress make us shop? One reason is our perceived sense of control. Feeling like there's something going on that you don't have control over will push you to do something that you *do* have control over, like choosing something to buy. When we said this in an episode of *Frugal Friends*, we got this response from a listener:

“Compulsive spending is such an issue for me. I've always tried to explain that shopping goes beyond the hit of dopamine. Control is the perfect word to use. I was thinking the other day, ‘Winter is 3 months away. My kids need winter coats and I'll feel less stressed about them not having them if I just buy them now.’ Then instead of taking the time to research and look for them secondhand or on sale I just immediately bought them. I always have this feeling of not being prepared, then buying something makes me feel more in control.”

Another cause of stress spending is distraction. When you shop in person, the store can stimulate your senses, sights, and smells that distract you from stress. Even the act of simply scrolling or window shopping can release dopamine through the anticipation of buying a possible reward or treat. We're all for spending money to celebrate big wins like landing a new job, paying off your debt, or . . . writing a book. But when you think about rewarding yourself with a little treat, because, I don't know, you made it all day without buying yourself a little treat? It's time to reevaluate whether you're celebrating or distracting yourself.

So how do we overcome stress shopping? We treat the root cause of the shopping: the stress. We have to manage the stressors in our control and find healthy coping mechanisms for the stressors outside our control.

First, eliminate what you can. Simplify your schedule and surroundings (or whatever in your life feels complex) and ask for support during difficult seasons. If this feels like a big task, try giving your season an arbitrary end date. That way you can always go back to what you were doing before but you have an excuse as to why you need to cut out some things or get assistance for a period of time.